

But two rather ordinary incomes are not enough to produce a family fortune. Two wage earners pay two taxes. With all the expenses of a two-wage family, too, there is not going to be enough money left over to build real family money. We'll look more at what you need to do to get a family fortune, even if it is a modest one, in the next chapter. You'll see that one person devoted to making money can earn far more than two who are only doing it in a perfunctory way. For now, let's just note that as a strategy for building family wealth, the two-income approach doesn't work.

But the even greater failure is on the other side, the family side. The lack of focused involvement on the part of any one single parent can cost a family dearly. No one has the time to make sure the children are emotionally fulfilled. No one can closely monitor if there are subtle conflicts between siblings. No one can instill a sense of duty upon the children. No one has the time to elaborate the family culture: the attitudes, rules, and reflexes needed to sustain an Old Money family.

Even if the two wage earners were able to put together the money for a family fortune, they would be unlikely to be able to put together the family itself. Over time, many are the threats to family wealth—most of them arising from the family members themselves. These are the things that can pull the family apart and ultimately destroy the family wealth.

Raising children properly is a critical family function. It should be the focus of one parent. There are numerous studies that confirm this.

And let's take it a step further.

The presumed bargain in the "social contract" with modern government is this: Families turn over a large part of their incomes to the government; the government provides education and some health care services. The less money you have, the harder it is for you to resist. But it comes at a high price. Not just in the taxes you pay or in the imminent bankruptcy of the welfare state, but also in terms of what it does to your family. Government-provided services, typically, are (1) not very good and (2) designed to enhance the power of the government.

Not that we have much experience with this, but the logic of our argument suggests that you're better off educating the children at home. Or at least surveying their education closely. Turn them over to the